



(FROM TOP)
VASUDEVAN C.,
CO-FOUNDER;
KARTHEESWARAN K.K.,
CO-FOUNDER AND
CEO; AND SHARATH
LOGANATHAN,
CO-FOUNDER

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and eager college graduates in the first three years. But as the organisation started growing fast, it was time to bring in more complementary and senior management skills. "Our concern was what the old-timers would think. Would they feel we were not betting on them anymore? That is bad signalling," says Kartheeswaran.

But the move was well received as everybody in the team had more people to learn from. The launch of Ninja Mandi, Ninja Kirana, Ninja Kisaan and Ninja Global around 2020 was a game changer in talent attraction. "Until then, it was operations-heavy. Now, it was more innovation-led. A good chunk of our team joined in the past 1.5-2

years," says Vasudevan.

The 'agritech' tag is Ninjacart's big differentiator among prospective employees. Half its team, including the main co-founders, has an agricultural connection. Ashutosh Vikram and Sachin Jose are no longer actively serving as co-founders in their current roles but they remain integral members of the founding team.

Loganathan says the perception is that if a Google or Amazon or Netflix is going to get built out of India, it is probably going to be from agriculture because it is so unique to India. That also helps hire the right talent, he adds.

"Generally, IIM students don't want to work in agri-based businesses. We think we made agritech a little more aspirational. Now we want to be the preferred employer in the entire start-up ecosystem," says Vasudevan.

The team claims they haven't fired anyone in the past 1-1.5 years of the start-up funding winter, which has triggered mass lay-offs in the ecosystem. The soonicorn, last valued at \$815 million in December 2021, says they have enough cash to pay corporate expenses for 4-4.5 years. But they need funds to expand to 200 cities by FY25 from the current 70. The larger goal is to build an organisation that outlives the founders. Even though their entry into agriculture was accidental, they have all had different takeaways from the journey so far. But it converges at one point. "Agri is a \$500-billion market," says Vasudevan. "Solving this will leave a legacy for a lifetime." **BT**

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